Safety Before Technique

Consent, receiving, and why the body opens only when it feels safe

by Lawrence Lanoff

Excerpted from Beyond the Myth: The Definitive Guide to Modern Tantra, Chapter 5 (Touch) and Chapter 5b (Receiving). Free reading copy. For adults (18+). Education, not therapy or medical care.
tantra-authority.com

Consent — what it actually is

If touch is the access, consent is the door.

The culture made consent into a legal abstraction, a checkbox, a script — do you give me permission to touch you here? That version isn't wrong, exactly, but it isn't what consent actually is at the level of the body, and treating the legal version as the whole thing leads to a lot of touch that's technically consented and somatically dead.

Real consent is something the body is doing in the moment — not a sentence that got said before the moment. The body either is, or is not, currently giving access. The body's signal is what consent actually is. The words help — words clarify, words name the thing, words let you check what you think the body's saying — but the words aren't the consent. The body is.

When the body's in real consent, it opens toward the touch. The breath stays deep. The skin under the hand stays warm. The face stays soft. The jaw stays unclenched. The pelvis stays alive. The body is in the encounter.

When the body's not in real consent — even when the words got said, even when the situation looks fine — the body does specific things. The breath goes shallow. The skin stays cool, or goes clammy. The face tightens. The eyes look somewhere else. The body holds still in a way that's closer to waiting-for-it-to-be-over. The pelvis goes dead. The body has checked out even though the encounter's still going.

If you're the one touching, your job is to read these signals as well as you read the words. The signals are more reliable. The body almost never lies; the words sometimes do, because words got trained over decades to say what's socially expected. I'm fine. It's okay. Keep going. The body's reporting the truth underneath. The honest move is to track both, and to stop or check when they disagree.

If you're the one being touched, your job is to honor what the body's reporting and to learn to put words to it. Stop for a second. Slower. Move your hand. Not there. Wait. Yes, there. These are some of the most useful sentences a body can learn to say. The partner worth being with wants the information. The partner who doesn't want it is showing you something about themselves.

The reading runs in a loop, and the loop is where the confidence comes from. You put down a really gentle feather touch — practiced right there in the moment, not planned, not performed — and you watch. The body gives you a response. And that response is the thing that builds your confidence, which lets you offer the next touch with a little more of you in it, which gets a bigger response, which builds more confidence. The loop feeds itself. Most people never start it because they never went gentle enough to get the first clean response back.

Watch the difference. The one who comes in and slaps their partner on the ass like a buddy — the same hand, the same body part — is going to read nothing back, build nothing, and they're never going to have a quality sex life, because there's no loop running. They're broadcasting; they're not receiving. Take that exact same approach and make it a feather touch instead — slow, light, attending — and it lands in a completely different place. Same hand. Same spot. The body answers one and goes dead to the other. The feather touch starts the loop. The slap kills it before it begins.

The basic rule, in plain English. Hell yes, or no. If the body's at hell yes, the door is open and the touch goes through. If the body's at anything less — at I guess, at I suppose, at fine, at I should want this — the door isn't actually open, and the touch is going to land wrong even if it gets tolerated. Hell yes isn't just a slogan. It's a real state in a real body. You can feel the difference when it's there. You can feel the difference when it's not.

Consent done this way is the only real prerequisite for everything in the rest of this book. Without it, all the technique in the world makes dead encounters. With it, almost any touch — clumsy, beginner, exploratory, slow — makes aliveness. The hell-yes door is the access. Everything that flows through it flows because the door is genuinely open.

This is what makes the work safe. Safety is the conditions that let a body release into an encounter: real consent, a partner reading the signal, a space where no is honored the moment it arrives. Everything else in this book happens inside that field.

There's one more piece, and it's the ethic that sits over all of it. When it comes to sex, you leave the campsite better than you found it. If you're going to enter someone and enter their world — participate with them, share an experience inside their body — you may as well leave them better than you found them. Not just unharmed. Better. Because the alternative isn't neutral: handle it carelessly and you're not only failing them in the moment, you're making it harder for whoever

comes after you, teaching their body one more time to brace on the way in. The generous move and the smart move turn out to be the same move. Leave the place more open than you found it.

This is why everything in this book runs on safety before technique. Not as a rule someone imposed. As a fact of how the equipment is built. The hands can do their part — slow, warm, patient, reading the signal. But the deepest opening is never something the hands take. It's something the body gives, once it's sure. The whole art is making the body sure.

Chapter 5b — Receiving

Someone puts a hand on you and you start working.

You reach back. You arch. You make the sound you think they want to hear. You try to be a good person to touch. It feels generous from the inside. Sometimes it is simply hard to let something arrive without paying for it immediately.

Receiving is its own practice. The person touching and the person being touched have different jobs, and neither job is smaller. When you are receiving, you can tell the other person what you want. Slower. Stay there. More pressure. Not there. Stop. The freedom to say no is part of the freedom to take in a real yes. Once that is clear, you don't have to perform gratitude with your body. You can feel the hand.

The person giving is allowed to enjoy giving. They get to feel their hands, the warmth of another body, the pleasure of learning what lands. The receiver gives them something real by being there to receive it. If both people keep trying to give at the same time, neither gets to know that half of the exchange.

Try that small. Ask someone you trust to hold your hand for a minute. If you want it. If they want it. Let the hand be held. Feel the weight, the warmth, where the fingers meet. If you notice yourself squeezing back because you think you owe an equal amount of touch, notice that too. You can squeeze because you want to. You can let your hand rest. You can change your mind halfway through. Nothing about receiving takes your choices away.

And you don't need another person to begin. Let the chair take your weight. Let the floor hold your feet. Feel water on the skin without rushing to turn it into a task. Put a hand on your own

arm and let the arm receive what the hand is doing. The giver and receiver are in the same body. That is still a real exchange.

Stay with the arm for a few breaths. Let the touching hand move only when the arm wants it to. If the touch is too light, give the arm more weight. If it is too much, ease up. Ask the arm instead of applying a technique from memory. You are learning both sides of the conversation in one skin.

I have taught giving and receiving as a cycle. Nature runs on inhale and exhale, not endless output. Force the breath out again and again without letting the next inhale come, and you find the limit quickly. Try to take in without ever letting anything out, and you find another limit. A body lives because both halves are available.

People can get stuck on either side of that rhythm. Some give until they are empty and resentful, then call the exhaustion love. Some take in and cannot let anything move outward. The answer isn't a rule about equal amounts. It is the freedom to notice which direction the current wants to move now, and to let the direction change.

Sometimes the receiver's old reflex is to protect the giver. Are they tired? Am I asking for too much? Should I be doing something back? Those questions can be useful when they are honest information from the room. They become a wall when they run automatically over every offer. You can ask. "Do you want to keep touching me?" A real yes is enough. Let the other adult own their answer, and let yourself own yours.

Receiving touch is one version. Receiving help is another. Someone offers you time, attention, a meal, a ride. Before you refuse, before you promise to pay them back, feel what the offer does in your body. You may want it. You may not. You are allowed to say no. If the answer is yes, let the yes arrive without turning it into a debt on the same breath.

The culture taught many of us that receiving without earning is dangerous. If I take this, I owe you. If I rest, I'm lazy. If I let you give to me, I lose my freedom. Those are stories, and they can feel like facts when they live in the body. You can find out what is true in this encounter instead of obeying a story written before either of you entered the room. A gift can be a gift. A touch can be wanted. An offer can also have a price you don't agree to. Read the person, read yourself, and choose.

The body gives you signals as you do this. A held breath. A jaw that tightens when somebody comes close. A belly that softens when the right person stays. The signals are information, not

orders. You can slow down and ask for what would make the encounter work for you. You can leave. You can stay. You can receive.

Later we'll go further into active and receptive, into two bodies exchanging energy, into the ways sex changes when either person can move in either direction. Start here, before the theory: let one real thing reach you. Notice what happens when you do not immediately send it back.

And then breathe. The inhale receives. The exhale gives. You are back at the first practice. Let the next breath come in.

Where to go next

If this landed, the next step is one of my two short books, written for one reader at a time.

Tantra for Men (eBook), $19.97

Tantra for Women (eBook), $19.97

And when you want the full program, step by step: Tantra X, $197.

Lawrence